the issue of Masood Azhar, which had pushed the Chinese into a cul-de-sac. Even in this difficult situation, they still hoped for some gain, and made a final effort to extract the last ounce of benefit before the compromise. The Chinese committed to a concrete time frame for the listing—post 23 May 2019, that is a date immediately after the results of India's general election.

The Americans tabled a draft resolution in the Council and put China on notice that it would call for a vote on the matter in the UN Security Council if the Chinese did not indicate its positive support for the draft resolution by 23 April 2019. This was known as the 'drop-dead' date. The Americans knew they had a clear majority of support in the Council. The Chinese also knew that they might have to exercise a veto. A division of vote in the Security Council, even if the overwhelming majority of membership voted for the American draft resolution, was not a desirable situation since it would mean not only a Chinese veto but also a possible Russian abstention. The Americans are believed to have offered a compromise. If China could agree to a specific time frame for the listing of Masood Azhar, the United States would not press the matter in the Council. China continued to ask that the date for Masood Azhar's listing be set for any date after 23 May 2019. They seemed to be using the Ayatollah Khomeini gambit—the American hostages in Iran had been released only after President Jimmy Carter relinquished office so that he might not utilize their successful release for re-election—to deny Prime Minister Modi any possible electoral benefit.

The Americans reportedly demurred and insisted that China agree to the listing on 1 May 2019. China realized that it had already paid a heavy price for defending its ally, Pakistan, and that it would get heavier still if they delayed a decision any further. China did not wish to stand alone in the Security Council; vetoing the US draft resolution was like cutting off